

SHRIYA PATIL



To Back or Not to Back

DELHI The Sanjay Dutt case seems to have turned into a slugfest with some of Delhi's legal eagles playing politics with the verdict. It was former attorney general Soli J. Sorabjee who fired the first salvo when he criticised Union ministers Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi and Kapil Sibal for supporting Dutt as this may send a message of a "celebrity justice delivery system". Immediately the science and technology minister, who has sparred with Sorabjee in many

cases, went in for a rebuttal. Sibal clarified that he had not commented on the merits of the case, nor was he speaking as a Cabinet minister but was reacting to media queries as Dutt's former lawyer. He also recalled that when Ram Jethmalani was removed as law minister in the NDA regime, he had lashed out against Sorabjee saying that the then attorney general "was no one's friend". Clearly there was more at play than just legal semantics.

FALLEN HERO: Dutt with sisters Priya (L), Namrata

The Congress, however, is still to come out in Dutt's support even though his sister who is a sitting MP called on Sonia Gandhi for "morale support". Immediately after the sentence, Dasmunshi had said that he felt the actor had suffered enough and that all efforts should be made for an appeal at the highest judicial level. Party spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi had distanced the Congress from his comments saying that these were his personal views and not the official stand of the party. Unfazed by this stand, Dasmunshi retorted that since he was the minister for broadcasting, the welfare of cine artistes came under his portfolio. He also added that "anyone who did not feel sympathy for Dutt should see a cardiologist because it means that the person has a heart problem". To add to the confusion, the Congress claims Sibal's comments differ from Dasmunshi's. Go, figure!

by Priya Sahgal

Cross-Party Hero

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

More than nine years in prison as an under-trial has physically and mentally transformed the once rabble-rousing Muslim cleric Abdul Nasser Madani, an accused in the 1998 Coimbatore blasts case. Acquitted of all charges by a sessions court, Madani, founder of the People's Democratic



REFORMED: Madani

Party, received a martyr's welcome in Kerala on his release where both the ruling LDF and the Opposition UDF vied with each other to cheer him.

A stint in jail has brought around a dramatic change in his attitude. "I admit to have done many wrongs in the past though I have never preached or practised terrorism as I have been accused of. I will continue to fight for the rights of the Muslim-Dalit sections but will never provoke any other sections by either word or deed. Tolerance and peace should not be given up at any cost," he said. Though Madani has reiterated his support to LDF, he has refused to join any party. The BJP, alone, opposed this reception saying he was responsible for the hostility between Hindus and Muslims and accused political parties of using their clout in getting him acquitted.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

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